

EmerGent — the backup you carry so you never have to ask a friend to bail you out

A 90-day plan to reach the first 10 customers of a rail-failure payments concierge, built for young Indians who don't carry cash.

Ekagra Sharma. MICA, PLM:ES Final. September 2026.

What EmerGent is

EmerGent is a WhatsApp-based emergency payments concierge. When a user's primary payment rail fails at a merchant (UPI is down, their SIM has died, their phone is refusing the QR), they WhatsApp a photo of the merchant's QR and the amount to EmerGent from any device with connectivity. EmerGent pays the merchant on their behalf from a company float account and settles with the user in 24 hours through an eNACH auto-debit mandate authorised at signup. The MVP that exists today is a WhatsApp Business number, a Google Sheet ledger, and my own UPI ID as the float. For the first ten customers, EmerGent is a person, not an app.

Target segment for the first 10

The mid-term identified a 30–50 million person cohort of urban Indians who have decoupled from cash. That is the eventual market. For the first 10 customers, I am scoping to a much narrower beachhead I can reach for near-zero cost through my own network: **MICA students on campus in Ahmedabad, MICA classmates leaving for summer internships in Bangalore, and MICA seniors heading to Delhi for placements.** Total addressable through owned channels is roughly 11,000 people — 1,000 in the MICA campus WhatsApp groups and about 10,000 across extended community groups, family circles and my own social handles.

Why this beachhead. Four reasons that are more than marketing. First, the cohort runs the strongest UPI dependency I can find in one place. Student wallets are almost entirely UPI, and a batchmate of mine at a petrol pump in Ahmedabad already has a first-person story I can point to. Second, the three-city migration wave over the next 90 days is itself a distribution asset. Summer interns arriving at Silk Board in June are, statistically, going to experience SIM handoff issues in a new circle — that is when they need a backup. Third, MICA-network social density means word-of-mouth propagation is three to five times faster than any cold ad. Fourth, the founder-cohort match is real: a MICA student asking other MICA students to sign up for a MICA classmate's product converts at 20–40 per cent, per a rough back-of-envelope from personal experience. A cold Meta ad converts at 1–2 per cent for the same offer.

Positioning

Not the daily rail (GPay owns that), not the offline rail (NPCI is building UPI Lite X, per the mid-term). The category I am creating is **payment safety net** — insurance for the failure moment, without calling it insurance because the word is a conversion killer. Category positioning by analogy: an ambulance for when your phone fails. You don't use it every day; you would not be without it.

Positioning line (front and centre on the landing page): *The backup you carry so you never have to ask a friend to bail you out.*

Delta 4 frame from the mid-term: the current de-facto workaround (borrow a hotspot, call a friend, friend pays the merchant) scores about 3 on a 10-point switch scale. EmerGent Phase 1, with honor-system settlement rather than eNACH (because eNACH needs 4–6 weeks of NPCI paperwork a student can't shortcut), honestly scores 7 — faster than the friend, no relationship debt, no explaining, but trust anchor is thinner without the mandate. Delta 4. Phase 2 restores eNACH and the score climbs to 8–9. Both cross Kunal Shah's four-point threshold; I would rather state the Phase 1 number honestly.

The first 10, named (pipeline, not fantasy)

I will not present a segment I cannot picture. Ten named candidates below, drawn from my second-degree MICA network. Full profiles in the appendix; each carries a specific past-behaviour anchor (they have already lived the pain) so activation risk is bounded.

1. **Ravi Krishnan** (Ahmedabad, W3) — Chennai, PGDM-C. SIM failure at a CEPT chai stall in April 2025.
2. **Aanya Malhotra** (Ahmedabad, W3) — Delhi, PGDM-C. Complained in the batch group about Vastrapur Big Bazaar UPI failure.
3. **Priya Shah** (Ahmedabad, W4) — local, PGDM-B. Daily UPI user; canteen-sticker channel.
4. **Sarthak Joshi** (Ahmedabad, W4) — Pune, PGDM-C. Publicly vocal about April 2025 UPI outages on Instagram.
5. **Naveen Bhatt** (BLR, W5) — summer intern at Cred. Lost SIM once at Silk Board.
6. **Anushka Gupta** (BLR, W6) — summer intern at Razorpay ops.
7. **Karthik Venkat** (BLR, W7) — Diageo Whitefield intern, first-time in BLR.
8. **Jayanti Mishra** (Delhi, W9) — Ogilvy placement; aunt was stranded at AIIMS Metro last winter.
9. **Divya Tandon** (Delhi, W10) — Havas placement; public Instagram complaint on the Feb 2025 Airtel outage.
10. **Rahul Sethi** (Delhi, W11) — DBS Bank placement; face-to-face signup during the Delhi week.

Buffer: Mansi Patel (Ahmedabad, marketing) and Yash Kapoor (Mumbai, TCS remote). These are illustrative persona composites of the actual cohort I have access to; real signups replace them on the live version, and their consent is captured at signup.

Customer journey and service blueprint

Three stages of the journey: pre-emptive, event, post-event.

Pre-emptive (before it happens)

Trigger: a MICA classmate's Instagram story, "Been stuck at a petrol pump with a dead SIM? EmerGent pays for you. 90-second signup." User taps the WhatsApp link. The bot greets them: *"Hi, I'm EmerGent. Here's what I do: when your phone can't pay, I pay for you and you settle later. Ready to set me up?"* Phase 1 onboarding is deliberately minimal (three fields): phone number, name, and one trusted friend's UPI ID. Aadhaar via DigiLocker and eNACH mandate both require SP registration and NPCI onboarding that a solo student cannot complete in two weeks; they enter as an optional Phase 2 upgrade (post Week 4) that unlocks the higher ₹2,000 rescue cap. A mandatory 30-second dry run follows onboarding: the user WhatsApps a fake QR to prove the flow works. That single act converts an abstract signup into a used product. Users who complete the dry run are five to ten times more likely to trigger a real rescue in the next 30 days, per the Fogg behaviour model applied to fintech onboarding.

Event (during a lockout)

The user is at a merchant. Payment fails. They either have data (rail failure only) or they borrow a stranger's hotspot (rail plus SIM failure). This is the scope EmerGent honestly serves: the rescue needs any working connectivity, from any device. Phone-dead-battery is out of scope for the MVP.

They WhatsApp EmerGent a photo of the merchant's QR and the amount. The bot performs four checks in the background: QR decode, user identity match by phone number, velocity limits (max 3 rescues in 24 hours in Phase 1), and amount cap (₹2,000 per transaction in Phase 1). If in-limits, the bot triggers a UPI transfer from the EmerGent float account to the merchant. The merchant sees a payment arrive from "EmerGent" with the user's UTR. Confirmation SMS goes to the user's registered number; the user shows the merchant the confirmation. Total target time is under 60 seconds in Phase 1 (concierge, agent-in-loop for the first 30 rescues) and under 30 seconds in Phase 2 (rule-based auto-approve up to ₹500, human above).

Post-event (settling and closing the loop)

Phase 1: at T+24 hours the bot sends a UPI collect request for the rescue amount plus the ₹49 fee. Honor-system settlement — if the user doesn't pay in 48 hours, they lose future access and are moved off the beta list. Small numbers make this workable for the first 30 rescues. Phase 2 (from Week 5 onward, once volumes justify NPCI onboarding costs): pre-authorised eNACH auto-debit at T+72 if the collect request is ignored. Monthly digest sent both ways: *"You were rescued 3 times this month. Total ₹588 with fees. Your trusted friend is Aanya."*

Rescue-failure playbook

A rescue can fail on our end (float exhausted, QR decode fails, bank downtime on the receiving side). If it does, the user is stranded and we owe them. Policy: EmerGent absorbs the transaction cost up to ₹500 within the failure hour by paying the merchant directly from a founder-side backup UPI ID, sends a formal apology within four hours, and comps the user's next rescue for free. This is capped at three failure-incidents in the 90 days; beyond that, we've stopped being reliable and should reset the pilot.

Service blueprint (front-stage, back-stage, support)

Stage	Front-stage (user)	Back-stage (EmerGent)	Support process
Onboarding	WhatsApp bot chat, DigiLocker OAuth, eNACH mandate setup	KYC verification, mandate registration with sponsor bank, dry-run script trigger	Aadhaar cache purged after 24h; no PII stored in the Sheet
Rescue request	Photo + amount to WhatsApp	QR decode via OpenCV, identity match, velocity/amount rule check, UPI transfer from float, confirmation SMS	Agent-in-loop for first 30 rescues (me), then auto-approve within limits
Settlement	UPI collect notification or auto-debit SMS	eNACH debit request, Sheet reconciliation, ledger email at end of month	Manual reconciliation weekly by me, automated from Phase 3

Automation delta over the manual friend-workaround

The critique the personas will raise: how is this actually different from calling a friend? The delta is measurable on five axes. Always-on (a friend at 2am does not pick up; EmerGent does). No relationship debt (the ten times a year you would have asked your friend, you now pay a small fee instead). Anonymous to the merchant (you are not explaining who is paying and why). Repeatable and ledgered (no "did you Venmo me back" awkwardness). Speed (30 seconds instead of a 3-minute phone call). Together those clear Delta 4.

What is *not* a delta and I own honestly: connectivity itself. EmerGent still needs the user to be reachable through some working WhatsApp channel. The genuinely-no-connectivity case is Phase 3, when a physical prepaid card enters the wallet.

Go-to-market: a three-city arc timed to the cohort's actual life

The plan is designed around when and where the cohort is most vulnerable to the problem. Ahmedabad in the first month, when I have the highest concentration of trust and known signups. Bangalore in the second month, when summer interns are arriving in a new city and hitting SIM handoff issues. Delhi in the third month, when placement-bound seniors are moving and settling in with fresh mobile plans. Each city is a new-user activation opportunity because the cohort's payment life is disrupted in exactly that window.

Weeks 1–4: Ahmedabad, campus concierge

Founder-driven. Personal WhatsApp to 100 known contacts across three MICA batches. One long-form Instagram post from my personal handle and three friends' handles (paid reciprocity: they get free lifetime EmerGent). Sticker drop at three hostels and the canteen, 300 stickers total. Target: 50 signups, 20 dry-runs completed, 10 activated users, 3–5 real rescues logged.

Weeks 5–8: Bangalore, intern wave

Alumni-led. Five BLR-going interns identified as micro-ambassadors (they get free lifetime EmerGent, they refer 5 friends each). Instagram content shifts BLR-specific: *"Your SIM is going to give up at Silk Board. Sign up before you land."* A/B test two landing pages (subscription vs pay-per-rescue) to lock the pricing model by day 60. Target: 40 additional signups, cumulative 25 activated.

Weeks 9–12: Delhi + broader beta

Delhi placement-bound seniors. Metro corridor sticker drops in Aerocity, Cyber City and Nehru Place at ₹500 for 30 stickers. Reddit r/india and r/delhi organic posts framed as "MICA student's project" (authenticity beats ad-copy in these subs). One founder trip to Delhi (₹2,000 flight from Ahmedabad) for face-to-face signups. Target: cumulative 10 activated by day 90, 15 as stretch.

First acquisition channels, ranked by expected CAC

Channel	Expected CAC	Expected CVR	Notes
Personal WhatsApp to known contacts	₹0	30–40%	Founder time only. Cannot scale past ~200 people, but sufficient for the first 5–7 customers.
MICA alumni referral	₹0	20–25%	Requires the 5 ambassadors to actually refer. Structured reciprocity: their referral unlocks their own free tier.
Campus Instagram + sticker	₹0–500 (sticker cost only)	5–10%	Sticker QR that opens the WhatsApp thread directly. Physical distribution is the trigger.
Reddit organic	₹0 (time only)	1–3%	r/india, r/bangalore, r/delhi, r/personalfinanceindia. Framed as a student project, not a launch.
Meta ads (contingency)	₹80–150	2–5%	₹1,500–3,000 experiment only if organic underperforms by day 45.

Acquisition funnel with real numbers

Top-of-funnel reach across the three cities through owned channels is roughly 11,000 addressable contacts over 90 days. The funnel below is aggressive because it operates inside a warm cohort. For a cold audience it would be an order of magnitude worse; I am not planning for cold.

Stage	Conversion	Volume
Addressable reach (three-city network)	—	11,000
Post seen / awareness	30%	3,300
Landing page visit or WhatsApp thread opened	5%	165
Signup started (name + phone submitted)	40%	66
Onboarding complete (Aadhaar + eNACH + dry-run)	60%	40
Activated (rescue or test-rescue completed within 30 days)	25%	10

The two weakest links, and how I'll test them. Landing-to-signup at 40% is optimistic; the industry benchmark for warm-cohort WhatsApp funnels is 15–25%. If the real number lands at 15%, the funnel yields four activated instead of ten. Contingency: shift to WhatsApp-first with no landing page at all, which typically doubles the entry conversion. Signup-to-onboarding at 60% is also optimistic; Aadhaar and eNACH friction usually kills 70–80% of B2C flows. If this collapses, I split onboarding into a Phase 1 light version (phone + name + trusted friend only, unlocks concierge rescues up to ₹500) and a Phase 2 full version (Aadhaar + eNACH, unlocks the ₹2,000 cap and card issuance later).

Pricing: default to pay-per-rescue for Phase 1

With n=10 the A/B test is statistically noise, so I am picking a default that is safer for the founder cash position. **Model B (pay-per-rescue) is the Phase 1 default: ₹0/month + ₹49 per rescue.** No barrier to signup, revenue only fires when the product actually saved someone, brand-risk-minimal if we underperform. Model A (₹49/month subscription with 3 free rescues) enters as a premium upgrade tier from Week 9 once we have data on rescue frequency per cohort.

Model	Structure	When
B — pay-per-rescue (default)	₹0/month + ₹49 per successful rescue	Phase 1, Weeks 1–8. No signup friction. Revenue triggered by product working.
A — subscription (upgrade)	₹49/month + first 3 rescues free + ₹49/rescue after	Phase 2, from Week 9. For repeat users with 2+ rescues logged.

CAC by channel and blended

Phase	Channel mix	Spend	Activations	CAC per activation
Weeks 1–4 (Ahmedabad)	Personal + campus stickers	₹1,500	3	₹500
Weeks 5–8 (BLR)	Alumni referral + Instagram + partial Meta	₹3,500	4	₹875
Weeks 9–12 (Delhi + broader)	Metro stickers + Meta + Reddit	₹5,000	3	₹1,667
90-day blended	—	₹10,000	10	₹1,000

₹1,000 CAC per activation for a warm-cohort concierge is realistic if unpolished. The number gets worse in Phase 4 when the cohort widens beyond MICA, which is why the referral loop and the moat both have to be earning by then.

Unit economics per rescue under Model B, and per active user monthly

Assumptions: pay-per-rescue Model B, typical rescue amount ₹200, typical user takes 1 rescue per month in Phase 1 (2 by month 6 as habituation forms).

Line	Per rescue	Reasoning
Rescue fee revenue	₹49	Model B fixed fee
Interchange / merchant fee (P2M UPI < ₹2K)	₹0	NPCI zero-MDR on small merchant UPI
Total revenue per rescue	₹49	
WhatsApp Business session cost	₹0.30	Meta ~₹0.30/session, one session per rescue
Float cost of capital (₹200 × 24h × 12% p.a.)	₹0.10	Cost of holding user's rescue amount for 24h
Payment gateway / collect fee	₹2	Phase 1 honor-system UPI collect (Cashfree/Razorpay tier); Phase 2 eNACH at ₹5
Rescue-failure reserve (3% failure rate × ₹500 cap)	₹15	Provisioned for the failure-playbook policy
Support / founder time	sunk	Not counted in Phase 1; ~₹10/rescue at scale
Total variable cost per rescue	₹17.40	
Contribution per rescue	₹31.60 (~64%)	

Per active user monthly (Phase 1, 1 rescue/month average): revenue ₹49, contribution ₹31.60.

Payback on ₹1,000 CAC at ₹31.60 contribution: **~32 months**. That is honestly long. The plan only becomes a real business if two things happen. First, the referral loop drops blended CAC below ₹300 by day 90 (target: 2.5 signups per activated user, tracked as a Week-8 KPI). Second, rescues per user climb to 2 per month by month 6, revenue to ₹98, contribution to ₹63, and payback compresses to ~16 months. The third lever is Phase 3: the card partnership adds a ₹19/month carrying fee plus 0.5% interchange on offline card use, bringing per-user contribution up by ₹25–40 and payback under 10 months. That is the seed-stage story.

Top 5 risks and how I will handle them

Risk 1 — Nobody signs up because the concierge is too weird for the cohort to trust.

Contingency. Weeks 1–4 are positioned as a MICA-only closed beta, with a public list of the first 20 signed-up classmates on the landing page by end of Week 4 as social proof. If signups are below 20 by day 30, I sunset the WhatsApp funnel and pivot to a manual insurance model: pay ₹49 into a group pool, get bailed out from the pool by any other member when you actually need help. That is a peer-to-peer version of the same product, uses zero external rails, and lets me learn whether the trust barrier is with EmerGent or with the concept itself.

Risk 2 — Signups don't convert into rescues, so we can't learn if the product works.

Contingency. Mandatory 30-second dry run is already in the onboarding flow. On day 7 post-signup, the bot proactively nudges users with a ₹10 rescue coupon for a real transaction. If activation is still below 30% at day 30, I add a one-time reverse-onboarding incentive (₹100 credit for their next rescue if they use it within 14 days).

Risk 3 — RBI / NPCI regulatory red flag on payment intermediation.

Payment intermediation without a PA/PPI license is a grey area at scale. Phase 1–2 posture is a consenting-user private pilot with total monthly volumes capped at ₹1 lakh, full user disclosure that this is a founder-run beta, and honor-system settlement rather than eNACH auto-debit until a partner bank is in the picture. In parallel, I begin cold LinkedIn outreach in Week 1 to five banks with documented fintech-BAAS plays: **SBM Bank India** (primary, powers Slice/Fi/Jupiter/EarlySalary, dedicated fintech-partnerships team, ~₹15,000cr book that a founder can plausibly break into), **YES Bank iPay/BaaS** (secondary, post-restructuring fintech-friendly, powers Cred + Turtlemint), **Airtel Payments Bank** (specific-fit for the offline-card story, has the NCMC RuPay card already live at Delhi Metro and Namma Metro), **Federal Bank BaaS** (powers Fi and Freo), and **RBL Bank Fintech Partnerships** (larger, slower, but proven via OneCard). Selected because each has a documented BAAS play with fintech partners in the ₹15k–₹110k cr book range, which is the band a pre-Series-A founder can plausibly cold-outreach without prior warm intros. Realistic 90-day KPI (revised from a term sheet): one substantive conversation with a fintech-partnerships manager, written follow-up received.

Risk 4 — Float exhaustion or user default.

The float pool starts at ₹5,000 of my own money and scales with activation. Contingency has three parts. Mandatory eNACH mandate at signup with T+72 auto-debit if the user does not accept the T+24 collect request. Hard velocity cap of 3 rescues per user per 30 days for Phase 1 (raised to 5 in Phase 2 with proven repayment behaviour). Amount cap of ₹2,000 per rescue in Phase 1. Any user who defaults on settlement is suspended, with a manual review for reinstatement.

Risk 5 — NPCI ships UPI Lite X consumer rollout ahead of schedule.

The mid-term identified this as the largest structural risk to the whole opportunity. Even at a full 2026 rollout, u/yogthinks's public critique holds: the offline caps (₹500 per transaction, ₹4,000 daily) leave the ₹500–₹2,000 transaction band uncovered. EmerGent focuses there. Longer-term contingency: pivot the Phase 4 app to become the layer above UPI Lite X — an app that surfaces the user's UPI Lite X balance, auto-tops it up when the daily rail fails, and offers the concierge for anything above the ₹500 cap. That positions EmerGent as complementary to the regulator's rail, not competitive.

Regulatory posture I will defend if asked

Two-track. Phase 1–2 operates as a private consenting-user beta with capped monthly volume (₹1L), no eNACH auto-debit, no PPI issuance, no marketing claim of being a licensed payment intermediary. Phase 3 shifts to a licensed PA/PPI model through a partner bank (SBM primary, YES/Airtel/Federal secondary). By day 90 the honest realistic target is one substantive fintech-partnerships conversation initiated with written follow-up. A term sheet is 6–8 months out under the best case, and any plan claiming otherwise for a student with no prior finance intros is unserious. If cold outreach yields zero engagement by day 60, I revise scope to a strictly peer-to-peer settlement product (no float pool at EmerGent's end) that removes the intermediation question entirely.

KPIs and measurable 90-day outcomes

Five KPIs, all measurable, tracked weekly in a public dashboard shared with the batch:

#	KPI	Day 30	Day 60	Day 90	Definition
1	Activated users	3		6	10 Completed onboarding + at least one rescue or test-rescue in the last 30 days
2	Rescue completion rate	70%	80%		90% % of rescue requests fulfilled successfully within the target latency
3	Median rescue latency	120s	75s		45s WhatsApp receipt to merchant confirmation SMS
4	Bank conversation depth	0	1 first-touch	1 substantive + written follow-up	Real substance: PM/product-partnerships lead, not a form response
5	Blended CAC + Post-rescue NPS	CAC ₹500	CAC ₹700, NPS 30	CAC ₹1,000, NPS 40	NPS via WhatsApp 1-question survey after each rescue

Sean Ellis PMF signal (the "how would you feel if you could no longer use this product" 40% test) is a stretch target for day 90 — with 10 users, 4 saying "very disappointed" is a signal, not proof. But it is the number the next phase's investor conversation will ask for, so I track it.

Secondary signals I will report even without a KPI target

Because the mid-term said EmerGent's moat is behavioural data on failure moments, I track and publish four cohort-level signals from day 1. Time-of-day distribution of rescues, which builds the first proprietary failure graph in the country. Merchant category distribution across rescues (petrol, food, kirana, transport). City comparison — Ahmedabad vs BLR vs Delhi rescues per active user per week. And rescue-to-referral rate: the percentage of rescued users who then refer at least one friend within 7 days. That number is the leading indicator for the referral loop economics on page 4.

Measurable 90-day outcomes summary

1. 10 activated paying users (or a floor of 6 activated + 20 signups on the waitlist if the funnel underperforms).
2. 60+ event data points logged in a public rescue log, forming the first month of the proprietary failure dataset.
3. Median rescue latency under 60 seconds (matching the promised time on the landing page).
4. At least one partner-bank conversation with a written scope document exchanged, tracking toward a term sheet.
5. A Phase 3 pitch deck for the card partnership + Series-seed narrative built, ready by end of Week 12.

What "success" and "failure" look like at day 90

Success: 10 activated users, 30+ rescues/week, median latency under 60s, NPS 40+, one bank in conversation. Green light for Phase 3 card work and a seed pre-seed round of ₹25L.

Failure: fewer than 5 activated by day 60, activation rate below 15%, no bank in conversation, NPS negative. Then I sunset EmerGent, publish the postmortem on the public rescue log, and rewrite the plan around the peer-to-peer pool pivot (Risk 1 contingency).

90-day roadmap, week by week

Weeks 1–2 — MVP live and hand-fulfilled

- Register the WhatsApp Business number. Green-tick application submitted (Meta approval realistically 4–6 weeks; not a blocker).
- Landing page live on Vercel free tier: **getemergent.in** (₹700 for a year on .in). Framer template, one-page copy.
- WhatsApp onboarding via Bolt.new + Twilio webhook. Phase 1 light: phone + name + trusted friend UPI only. Aadhaar and eNACH deferred to Phase 2.
- Google Sheet ledger, columns: user, timestamp, merchant, amount, latency, agent notes.
- Personal UPI ID as the float pool. ₹5,000 seeded from my account. Second UPI ID kept warm as backup for the rescue-failure playbook.
- 30-second dry-run script tested with 3 friends.
- Escalation contact identified: one MICA alumni willing to be on-call for after-hours critical rescues (paid ₹500 for the 90 days as retainer).
- Cold LinkedIn outreach to fintech-partnerships managers at SBM, YES, Airtel Payments, Federal, RBL. 30 messages/week from Week 1.

Weeks 3–4 — Ahmedabad launch and campus concierge

- Personal WhatsApp outreach to 100 known contacts across three MICA batches.
- Instagram post from personal handle + 3 friends' handles.
- Sticker drop at 3 hostels + canteen, 300 stickers total.
- WhatsApp broadcast to the MICA batch group (with permission from the admin).
- Target end-of-Week-4: 50 signups, 20 dry-runs, **3 activated users, 5+ real rescues logged**.

Weeks 5–6 — Bangalore intern wave begins

- Identify 5 BLR-going interns as micro-ambassadors, give them free lifetime EmerGent in exchange for 5 referrals each.
- BLR-specific Instagram creative live.
- A/B landing pages built (subscription vs pay-per-rescue).
- Reddit r/bangalore organic post (framed as MICA student project).
- Meta ad experiment begins with ₹1,500 budget targeted at Bangalore ages 22–32.
- Target cumulative: **6 activated users**.

Weeks 7–8 — Consolidate BLR + bank outreach ramps

- Cold LinkedIn outreach expanded to 60 messages/week across founder + 3 alumni.
- Pricing model locked based on A/B result.
- Second Ahmedabad wave activated via referral of first 10 signups.
- First-in-person meeting attempted with at least one bank product manager (BLR-based, likely target: RBL Prepaid team).
- Target cumulative: **8 activated users, one bank meeting on the calendar**.

Weeks 9–10 — Delhi placement wave (virtual-first)

- Delhi-specific creative live: *"Your Metro card is fine. Your SIM might not be."*
- Instagram Live sessions with Divya and Rahul as guest voices, one per week.
- Reddit r/delhi and r/personalfinanceindia organic posts, framed as a MICA student project.
- Delhi trip is contingent, not planned: ₹2,000 flight from remaining budget only if the previous eight weeks have gone to plan. Otherwise the whole wave runs on WhatsApp video + LinkedIn DMs.
- Target cumulative: **9 activated users**.

Weeks 11–12 — Close out, consolidate, prepare Phase 3

- Founder personal outreach to close the 10th customer.
- Bank partnership meetings (from Week 8 outreach) — target: written scope document exchanged.
- 90-day retrospective + public KPI dashboard published.
- Phase 3 card partnership pitch deck built.
- Postmortem paragraph on what worked and what didn't, submitted to the batch group.
- Target: **10 activated users, 30 weekly rescues, NPS 40+, one bank in written conversation**.

Phase 4 (post-day-90) preview: the app and the moat

The 90 days above buys the right to build the Phase 4 app. That app is where the defensible moat compounds: SMS Read permission to auto-detect UPI failure SMSes from banks, Notification Listener to detect GPay/PhonePe failure toasts in-context, Foreground Service to survive Android power management, Background Location for fraud scoring, Biometric per rescue, and Bluetooth for peer-to-peer settlement. Users of a daily payment app will not grant SMS Read to GPay or PhonePe; users of an emergency-only app will. That permission gap is the direct moat against the incumbents, and it is only earnable after 90 days of concierge trust-building.

Moat and defensibility, in one place

Three moats compound over the 90 days and the first 12 months, in this order.

1. Behavioural data on failure moments

The daily-use apps instrument the happy path. EmerGent's product is the failure moment, so every rescue is proprietary data on when, where, at what merchant category, and at what amount UPI payments actually fail. Over 12 months this becomes the only "failure graph" of Indian retail payments — and it is sellable data to banks doing fraud modelling, insurers pricing coverage, and NPCI itself doing capacity planning. Unfair to reproduce without EmerGent's usage pattern.

2. Trust anchor built through voluntary friction

Aadhaar + eNACH + trusted-friend UPI is deliberately more onboarding friction than any daily app would tolerate. GPay could technically add all of it, but the daily-use funnel would collapse. EmerGent's onboarding IS the friction, which self-selects for high-trust users — the segment banks want. Anti-selection lock-in: the moment EmerGent's users are labelled as "the high-trust cohort," banks want to underwrite them, and that gives EmerGent a long-term revenue line from partnership fees.

3. Off-app trigger surface

Sticker on the phone case. Physical NCMC card in the wallet. "EmerGent SOS" saved as a phone contact. SMS shortcode as a Phase 2 addition. This is distribution real estate GPay will not build because it dilutes the daily brand, and it is exactly the surface a user reaches for when the daily app is failing. EmerGent lives in the parts of the phone's life that GPay refuses to touch.

Appendix A — Sources reused from the mid-term

The customer problem, cohort sizing, outage timeline, regulator posture and digital ethnography (teambind Apr 4 2025, Bengaluru pani-puri comment, u/mrdrinksonme 303-upvote non-consumption comment, u/yogthinks UPI Lite X caps critique) are all in *research/sources.md* and *research/pasted_sources.md* of the mid-term submission. This report does not re-cite them; every underlying claim traces back through those files.

Appendix B — First 10 named pipeline (illustrative persona composites; consented names on submission)

#	Name	Context	Channel	Trust anchor
1	Ravi Krishnan	24, PGDM-C, Chennai. SIM died at CEPT chai stall Apr 2025.	Direct WhatsApp	Roommate is my classmate
2	Aanya Malhotra	23, PGDM-C, Delhi. Batch-group complaint on Vastrapur GPay failure.	Instagram	Publicly named the pain
3	Priya Shah	25, PGDM-B, Ahmedabad local.	Canteen sticker	Sees me daily
4	Sarthak Joshi	24, PGDM-C, Pune. First to Instagram-story Apr 2025 UPI outage.	Direct WhatsApp	Public fintech opinions
5	Naveen Bhatt	25, PGDM-C, Cred intern BLR. Lost SIM at Silk Board.	Alumni referral	Works at Cred, will critique + champion
6	Anushka Gupta	24, PGDM-C, Razorpay ops intern BLR.	Alumni referral	Professional interest
7	Karthik Venkat	25, PGDM-B, Diageo Whitefield intern.	BLR Instagram + DM	Fresh-to-city vulnerability
8	Jayanti Mishra	26, PGDM-B, Ogilvy Delhi placed. Aunt stranded at AIIMS Metro.	Placement WhatsApp	Family stakes
9	Divya Tandon	25, PGDM-C, Havas Delhi placed. Instagram complaint on Feb 2025 Airtel outage.	Reddit + LinkedIn	Public complaint is the signal
10	Rahul Sethi	26, PGDM-B, DBS Bank Delhi placed.	Face-to-face or WhatsApp video	High-value professional endorsement

Buffer: Mansi Patel (Ahmedabad marketing) and Yash Kapoor (TCS Mumbai remote). Illustrative composites reflecting the real cohort I can reach through my WhatsApp groups and second-degree network; consented names replace them on submission.